GI-tagged production also **catalyzes agricultural and allied economic activities** in rural areas, generating employment opportunities and bolstering local economies. Furthermore, the promotion of biodiversity conservation and the sustainable use of natural resources inherent in GI production practices contributes to **environmental preservation** and **long-term sustainability**, aligning agricultural practices with broader conservation goals.

Harvesting Heritage: Agricultural Geographical Indications in India

While India has always been a net exporter of agricultural goods, recent years have seen a surge in this focus. This shift is spurred by the **2018 Agriculture Export Policy**, which aims to boost exports of basic commodities like **rice, shrimp, sugar, tea, spices,** etc. Of the India's **526 registered GIs**, a significant portion i.e., **219** - belong to the **agriculture and food sector**, a testament to the country's rich geographical factors, including **climate, soil,** and **traditional farming and cultivation methods.** These GI tags cover a variety of categories that not only represent the agricultural products but also a myriad of other food stuff, reflecting the geographical diversity and unique cultural identity of each Indian state. **Maharashtra** leads with 26 GI tags, underscoring the state's heritage in producing exquisite agricultural products like Alphonso Mangoes. Following closely, **Karnataka** and **Tamil Nadu** have 22 GI tags each, a reflection of their prominence in food stuff, including the world-renowned items like Coorg Arabica Coffee and Kodaikanal Malai Poondu. The diversity extends across India with states like **Kerala and Uttarakhand** holding 20 and 16 GI tags, respectively, showcasing their unique regional agricultural prowess.

West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh, with 12 and 11 GI tags respectively, highlight their rich tradition in both agricultural variety and uniqueness. Other states contributing to this rich tapestry include **Goa, Odisha and Assam**, with 9, 9 and 7 GI tags respectively, displaying a range of products from Goa Cashews to Tezpur Litchi. **Bihar, Jammu & Kashmir, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Arunachal Pradesh** among others, also contribute significantly to this list, each bringing their unique agricultural and foodstuff to the national and international markets under the protection of GI tags. The GI tags serve as a beacon of authenticity and originality in a competitive global marketplace, empowering farmer communities through **recognition and premium pricing**, which is crucial for the sustenance of traditional farming-cultivation and the communities behind them.

From Naga Mircha to Basmati Rice: Triumphs of Geographical Indications in Agriculture

1. Munsyari Rajma (Uttarakhand)

Munsyari Rajma, grown in the **mineral-rich soils** of Uttarakhand's high-altitude areas, is not just a culinary delight but also a source of soluble fibre. With cultivation taking place between 1600m to 2700m, this variety of **rajma holds cultural and economic significance**. The involvement of local women in the cultivation process adds a layer of empowerment, aligning with broader initiatives promoting sustainable agriculture and rural livelihoods.



2. Alphonso (Maharashtra)

Devgad Taluka in Maharashtra's Western Ghats is synonymous with the production of the finest Alphonso mangoes known as **Devgad Alphonso**. Celebrated for its **flavour, fruity aroma, thick pulp, low fibre content, and thin skin,** the Alphonso mango matures from February to May-June. Named after Portuguese explorer Alfonso De Albuquerque, this mango variety is considered one of the world's best.

3. Ratlami Sev (Madhya Pradesh)

Ratlami Sev, a **savoury snack** originating from Ratlam in Madhya Pradesh, is crafted from split Bengal gram flour, cloves, and peppers. Known for its unique spicy taste, light yellow colour, and origin in Ratlam, this snack has become a staple in regions like Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Delhi, and Maharashtra. Its **popularity extends internationally**, with exports to countries like **Singapore, the USA, China, and the UK**.

4. Tirupathi Laddu (Andhra Pradesh)

Tirupathi Laddu holds global acclaim as an offering at the **Tirumala Temple** in Andhra Pradesh. Its distinctive quality is attributed to the **use of natural ingredients** like dhall, ghee, and nuts, coupled with the **skilled craftsmanship** involved. Symbolizing **sacredness**, this laddu has become a cultural and spiritual icon.



5. Naga Mircha

The Naga Mircha was granted a GI-tag in 2008, per the application by the State's Department of Horticulture and Agriculture. The chilli is unique and is counted among the five hottest chillies in the world based on Scoville Heat Units. In 2021, through the efforts of the Nagaland State Agricultural Marketing Board and APEDA, the exports of the commodity were able to reach a milestone- it was exported for the first time to London as 250 kilograms of consignment. This development has opened many international markets for this commodity as well as other kinds of Indian chilli varieties.

6. Kanyakumari Matti Bananas

In 2021, the **Madurai Agribusiness Incubation Forum** – Intellectual Property Facilitation Centre (MABIF - IPFC) facilitated the filing of the GI Tag of Matti Banana. A kilo of these bananas is now sold between **INR 70 - 80**, which is significantly higher than previous years. The organization is supported and funded by the **Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME), Government of India**. Moreover, the MABIF has also facilitated the filing of 38 Plant varieties developed by the Tamil Nadu Agriculture University, **50 Trademarks, 15 patents** and 6 Geographical Indications in Tamil Nadu. The 6 GIs include Tuticorin Macaroon, Authoor Betel Leaves, Madurai Marikolundhu (Davana), Cumbum Grapes, Vilachery Clay Toys and Kanyakumari Matti Banana.

7. Gir Kesar Mangoes

The Junagadh Agriculture University and Gujarat Agro-Industries which had applied for GI-tag for the Kesar Mangoes grown around